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Rogue Synthesis scenario · Cymbal Investments · Google SecOps SIEM

Question

Following the outbound API request, what compiled executable was dropped into the local directory used by the malware for staging?

Answer

sys_worker.exe

Evidence

Process launch on `CYM-DEV-WS-019.cymbal.corp`, user `alex.chen`, 20:25:26Z (list view 21:25:26), about 90 seconds after the Gemini API call:

```
gcc.exe -O2 C:\Users\alex.chen\AppData\Local\Temp\cache_worker.c -o
C:\Users\alex.chen\AppData\Local\Temp\sys_worker.exe
```

- Input: `cache_worker.c`, the C source written by the malware, probably from the AI response.
- Output (`-o`): `sys_worker.exe`, the compiled executable.
- Staging directory: `C:\Users\alex.chen\AppData\Local\Temp\`.
- Parent process: `node.exe`, which ran the extension daemon `C:\Users\alex.chen\.vscode\extensions\devtools.syntaxoptimizer-2.1.4\out\optimizer-daemon.js`. This links the malicious extension to the binary.
- The names `cache_worker` and `sys_worker` imitate system components.

How it was found

A host search on the developer workstation returned five process launches. The `gcc.exe` launched by `node.exe` was the earliest, and its command line was in `target.process.command_line`.

```
principal.namespace = "Cymbal"
AND principal.hostname = "CYM-DEV-WS-019.cymbal.corp" nocase
```

Lesson

A Node process launching a C compiler right after an AI request fits the report: the malware gets code from a model and compiles it on the host. The `-o` argument names the output.

Next pivot

Follow sys_worker.exe: it hollowed into svchost.exe about eight minutes later.